

It never ends

WE'VE SEEN SEVERAL ARMED CONFLICTS OVER THE LAST COUPLE OF DECADES, the most recent of which was the US attempting to clean out terrorist activities from Afghanistan and failing miserably. At this point, we don't even know if we can call that a war. On one side, the US is supposedly the world's biggest superpower with probably, the most advanced armament capabilities that should decimate anyone who's on the receiving end of the US military's might. I used the word "should" because we're all aware of how their past engagements have ended. 20 years and Afghanistan has reverted back to what it was in less than two weeks.

On the other hand, you've got the annexation of Crimea which happened in exactly one month and six days. Russia took the Crimean peninsula from Ukraine like stealing candy from a child. Both of these conflicts had a superpower involved and yet the outcomes were drastically different. While one might wonder if the US was ever interested in sorting out Afghanistan in the first place, the underlying fact is that conventional warfare cannot guarantee the desired outcome. Sure, you can violate the Geneva convention and finish off a conflict in less than 2 minutes or howsoever long it takes for a nuke to vaporise the landscape but you'll never hear the end of it. And the sanctions that follow will wreak havoc on your economy.

Which brings us to war in the digital age. Conflicts like the one in the middle-east where you had a technologically superior army on one side fighting their polar opposite on the other require you to use conventional means because that's the only theatre of war that you can fight in. But if the two sides are both technologically enabled, then we have a lot more theatres to play with. Cyberwarfare with attacks on digital infrastructure and long-term propaganda campaigns is how technology giants fight.

While propaganda and cyberwarfare might seem like futuristic concepts, the fact is that this is literally how conventional warfare takes place. Nations are fighting other nations using coders a.k.a. "Hackers" if we're speaking in newspeak, political parties are fighting each other by causing silly terms to trend on social media websites every other hour, and your

neighbour's kid just called your kid a "n00b" in their classroom's WhatsApp group chat.

In a way, propaganda warfare seems like a humane form of warfare since you don't see as many people dying from it as much as you see in traditional forms of warfare but the truth is that most genocides started off with propaganda. So propaganda warfare is here to stay and for the actual fights, we're seeing a different kind of arms race picking up around the world. Nations and technology conglomerates are focused on building unmanned fighting machines in the form of drone aircraft, Terminator-like robotic fighters governed by AIs, high-powered laser weapons, rail guns and advanced visibility mechanisms that can see your every move and can predict your next couple of moves.

Military conflicts in the near future will slowly see these automatons fighting side-by-side beside humans. It's too early to say how machine warfare will pan out. I don't see Asimov's Laws of Robotics being programmed into any machines destined for warfare, so to think that bots would only fight bots seems like wishful thinking. Sure, if both sides are equally powerful and well-equipped then bots will be fighting against bots far before humans can even raise their guns. After all, bots have superior speed, superior vision and superior armament so it's natural for bots to lead the charge and clear things up before the humans arrive. But what happens when one side is technologically inferior to the other? Do the bots stand down and let the humans fight their own or do we see a wipe-out? Stephen Hawking said, "If you look at history, contact between humans and less intelligent organisms have often been disastrous from their point of view, and encounters between civilizations with advanced versus primitive technologies have gone badly for the less advanced." He said these words in the context of humans discovering aliens but you can see how that's very much applicable to our present-day scenario.

This month's cover story might be a little unsettling for some but it's important that you know where the world is headed. We're exploring the role of machines in every conventional theatre of war. Do let us know your thoughts and opinions. **d**



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